Organizational Systems — Module 06: Learning — Discussion Questions

> 20 unique questions on organizational learning, model updating, and learning failures.

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1. How does framing organizational learning as "generative model updating" differ from the traditional view of learning as "knowledge accumulation"?

2. Explain the difference between single-loop and double-loop learning with a non-business example (e.g., cooking, sports), then translate to an organizational context.

3. IBM's transformation from hardware to services required double-loop learning. Why is double-loop learning harder than single-loop? What organizational forces resist it?

4. What is a "competency trap"? Why do organizations with deep expertise in one area find it hardest to learn in adjacent areas?

5. How does the concept of "prediction error" provide a more precise definition of learning than traditional definitions? When the organization is surprised, what exactly must update?

6. Organizations often claim to have a "learning culture." Using Active Inference, define what a genuine learning culture would look like — in terms of model updating, prediction error processing, and structural support.

7. Why is **superstitious learning** (attributing success to the wrong cause) so common in organizations? How would you design a system to detect it?

8. What is the relationship between organizational hierarchy and learning speed? Do flat organizations learn faster than hierarchical ones?

9. Post-mortems after failures are common. Post-mortems after successes are rare. Using Active Inference, explain why this asymmetry is a problem.

10. How do **defensive routines** (Argyris) prevent learning? Give an example of a defensive routine you have observed in an organization.

11. Audit the learning loops in your organization. For each (operational, tactical, strategic, transformative), describe: What triggers the loop? Who is involved? What gets updated? How effective is it?

12. Describe a time when your organization failed to learn from an obvious mistake. Diagnose the failure using the categories from the module (superstitious learning, competency trap, defensive routines, learning myopia).

13. Design a "learning system" for a specific challenge in your organization. Specify the feedback loop, data collection mechanism, cadence, and decision process.

14. Your organization just completed a major project that failed to meet its objectives. Design a post-mortem process based on Active Inference principles — focusing on which model predictions were wrong, what sensory data was missed, and what model updates should result.

15. Compare how a hospital and a software company learn from errors. What structural differences explain different learning rates? What could each learn from the other's approach?

16. How does employee turnover affect organizational learning? When experienced employees leave, what happens to the generative model? Design a knowledge preservation system.

17. Your CEO wants the organization to "innovate faster." Translate this request into Active Inference terms. What specific parameters of the learning system would need to change?

18. Organizations often benchmark against competitors. Using Active Inference, explain why vicarious learning (learning from others) is valuable but potentially dangerous if the other organization's context differs from your own.

19. Design an experiment to test whether your organization's quarterly business review actually produces belief updating or is primarily a performance theater ritual.

20. How does the length of feedback loops affect learning quality? Compare industries with rapid feedback (e-commerce, where you see results in days) with slow feedback (pharmaceuticals, where drugs take years to develop and evaluate).